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THE MEDIEVAL ORIGINS OF RELIGIOUS WHITE SUPREMACY: ENGLISH IMPERIALISM, CRUSADE DEFEATS, AND THE DOCTRINE OF DISCOVERY

Abstract

English identity's origin myth, Bede's eighth-century *Ecclesiastical History of the English People*, laid the foundation for European whiteness, which was adopted by western European Christians more broadly in the thirteenth century, as they sought assurance of God's preference for them over the darker-skinned Muslims who had defeated them in the crusades. Concurrent with their construction of whiteness, the English developed an imperialist Christian identity defined by the whims of power, not actual Christian belief or behavior, as most fully attested in the twelfth-century English invasion and subsequent colonization of Ireland. These developments gave rise in the fifteenth century to the papal letters commonly called the Doctrine of Discovery, which fueled European settler colonialism around the world. Once the English began colonizing lands beyond Europe, they also started to characterize the Irish—who largely share the same skin color as the English—as physically black. Understanding the origins of white supremacy and its fellow traveler, Christian supremacy, along with their false foundations and their history of dehumanizing an ever-rotating cast of targets to justify colonization, oppression, and enslavement, can better equip us to more effectively combat their contemporary manifestations and avoid their perpetuation, which threatens the entire planet.

Keywords: *Christianity, Crusades, England, Ireland, Medieval*

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Contrary to the common claim that "whiteness" first emerged in the seventeenth century, after Europeans started colonizing the rest of the globe and enslaving and exploiting darker-skinned people, it actually lies at the root of English identity. Bede's eighth-century *Ecclesiastical History of the English People* includes a tale that explains how "English" (Angli in Latin) became the ethnonym for diverse Germanic tribes who invaded and occupied much of Britain after the Romans withdrew in the fifth century. These tribes, mainly Angles, Saxons, and Jutes, had wrested a significant portion of Britain from the Britons (today better known as Welsh) to eventually create seven kingdoms, the heptarchy. Angles dominated in three: Bede's home, Northumbria, in the north, bordered by Mercia to the south, which bordered the third Anglian kingdom, East Anglia, on its east and Wales on the west. Saxons dominated in three kingdoms ringing Mercia to the south and east, the largest being Wessex (West Saxons), which extended to Cornwall and was bordered by Sussex (South Saxons) to the east, while Essex (East Saxons) lay to Sussex's north and East Anglia's south. Jutes oversaw a single kingdom, Kent, on Britain's southeastern tip. Despite their military dominance over the Britons, these tribes remained vulnerable to slave raiders, as with a group of sixth-century children who were abducted from Northumbria and sold in Rome's slave market. Here the future Pope Gregory the Great, then just a cleric, encountered them and, enchanted by "their bodies white (*candidi corporis*), their countenances beautiful, and their hair very fine," asked of their country of origin. Told they come from Britain, "where all the people have this appearance," he asked if Britain's inhabitants "were Christians, or whether they were still ignorant heathens. 'They are pagans,' he was informed. 'Alas!'" he sighed before asking "the name of th[eir] race[.]' 'They are called Angles,' he was told. 'That is appropriate,' he said, 'for they have angelic faces, and it is right that they should become joint-heirs with the angels in heaven.'"[2]

Gregory's connection between Angles and angels as well as between whiteness and salvation has had louder historical echoes than the facts that he was talking about trafficked and enslaved children and that when he was pope he had a representative, fittingly yet ironically named Candidus (meaning white or radiant), use the papal patrimony to purchase "English boys," aged 17 or 18, in Marseille.[3] Those aspects have been muted in favor of the focus on Gregory's enthusiasm for the boys' angelic appearance which inspired him to initiate the mission to England, or more specifically Kent, which Bede emphasizes as the catalyst for Christianizing the English and making them God's new chosen people. Moreover, due to Latin's gendered grammar, the masculine plural could include females, perhaps even as the majority, but it is as boys that the story gets told. The ways in which religion and slavery intertwine in whiteness's

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[2] Bede, Ecclesiastical History of the English People, ed. and trans. Leo Sherley-Price and R. E. Latham (London: Penguin Books, 1990; originally published 1951).

[3] Paul Ewald and Ludo M. Hartmann, eds., Gregorii I Papae Registrum Epistolarum (Munich: Monumenta Germaniae Historica, 1992).

foundational construction also should be noted, particularly given the horrors the English and other Europeans would eventually inflict as they colonized the rest of the world and proclaimed themselves the white Christian saviors of the indigenous peoples they enslaved.

Despite the concerning context in which it arose, *non Angli sed Angeli* (not Angles but Angels) has since functioned as a kind of ethnic slogan for the English. The story effectively named the English *qua* English, instead of Saxons (as they remained to the Irish, Welsh, and Scots, among others), Jutes, or anything else. As Patrick Wormald notes, "English identity was not, like Frankish or (Continental) Saxon, the badge of the most successful of the peoples contesting supremacy in a given sphere. It was what each Anglo-Saxon was called in heaven," an identity conceived "in the mind of God."[4]

The ethnonym also gained prominence through Gregory's consistent use of "Angles" regarding the evangelizing mission he sponsored to Kent starting in the late sixth century, even after he gained greater familiarity with Britain's inhabitants beyond enslaved children on sale in the Roman Forum and probably learned that this was not the most appropriate term, especially not for Kent's Jutes.[5] When Alfred, a West Saxon king, created nationalist propaganda for Wessex in the ninth century, he chose Gregory's angelic Angles and Bede's ecclesiastical history as primary instruments in forging a common identity among those he ruled.

This propaganda gave rise the following century to an actual England more or less along the boundaries we know it today under Alfred's grandson Æthelstan, who in 927 was able to add Bede's Northumbria to his domains, which already included the rest of the heptarchy as well as parts of Cornwall. England fell to the Danes from 1016 until 1042 and then to the Normans in 1066—an ephemerality utterly obscured by the ongoing romanticization of a mythical eternal Anglo-Saxon England among white supremacists and less overt racists in the United States today. During the not-quite century in which it stood, Anglo-Saxon England experienced recurring attacks and incursions by the Danes who would eventually take it, motivated in part by King Æthelred the Unready's attempted massacre of all Danes in England in 1002. Danes, like Normans, were basically settled Vikings, a name that is more job description than ethnicity, meaning sea-raider or pirate. Since the end of the eighth century, Vikings had attacked communities throughout Europe, especially near coasts or wherever rivers might take them. Their primary objective was people and goods that they could sell for wealth; thus, the English knew that their own children—or they themselves—could all too easily share the fate of Gregory's beautiful boys, sold into slavery far from home. This fueled anxiety and insecurity which shaped Abbot Ælfric of Eynsham's retelling of the "not Angles but Angels" myth in the late tenth century.

In his Old English homily to honor Gregory's birthday, Ælfric centered Gregory's alleged encounter with angelic English slaves, although he aged them so that they were "men white of body and beautiful of visage [*hwítes líchaman and fægeres andwlitan menn*]," while also calling them "youths" whose beauty prompted Gregory to ask after their origin.[6] When he learned that they were pagans, Gregory sighed, "Alas, that men of such a beautiful hue are subjected to the

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[4] Patrick Wormald, "The Venerable Bede and the 'Church of the English,'" in The English Religious Tradition and the Genius of Anglicanism, ed. Geoffrey Rowell (London: Abingdon Press, 1992), 13–32.

[5] Sarah Foot, "The Making of Angelcynn: English Identity before the Norman Conquest," Transactions of the Royal Historical Society 6 (1996): 25–49.

[6] Kathy Lavezzo, Angels on the Edge of the World: Geography, Literature, and the English Community, 1000–1534 (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2006).

black devil [*sweartan deofle*]," intensifying what in Bede's telling had been "the author of darkness." As Kathy Lavezzo argues, Ælfric's alterations to the story create "a highly complex national fantasy" that celebrates English geographic isolation, embodied in the enslaved males' beautiful otherness, as it also evokes ongoing concerns about English vulnerability to attack and enslavement. The English continued to enslave each other as punishment for crime and debt—not unlike what the Thirteenth Amendment enables in the United States—but the greater perceived threat was vulnerability to Viking attacks leading to enslavement, especially among Muslims, the primary market for Europeans trafficked by Vikings.

Ælfric's homily draws on centuries of Christian colorism that marks good and evil as white and black, connecting the latter with a skin color ascribed to Middle Eastern Muslims as well as Africans and the Welsh. His "fantasmatic construction" of whiteness derives its primary meaning in opposition to blackness, portraying the enslaved youths as angelic beings temporarily in the devil's power in order to enable them to recover their innate Christian identity, attested by their physical appearance. In Lavezzo's words, "Ælfric fashions these boyish signs of barbaric strangeness into emblems of Christian election [… These] white angels on the edge of the world [… who are] 'always already' Christian[, …] render a sovereign spiritual identity the birthright of a divided English people."[7] They encapsulate the simultaneous vulnerability and dominance of the English, a status so inherently insecure as to rely on something as superficial yet supposedly inalterable as skin color as proof of divine preference. Particularly for people with fair complexions, skin color offers only illusory stability, with a sunburn, tan, or even a freckle or birthmark potentially jeopardizing any assumption of angelic likeness. Ælfric intended his homily to be used by priests across England, reminding parishioners of their elect status, inscribed, like circumcision, upon their flesh, yet in far less permanent manner, as they contemplated the chaos and violence that undermined their collective claim to superiority.

This insecurity intensified with ongoing losses in the crusades, the original white Christian "Lost Cause," as the U.S. Civil War later became to American southern whites. Pope Urban II called the First Crusade in 1095, ostensibly to reclaim the Holy Land for Christ. Using military victories as the measure, initially the crusades were successful, resulting in the Catholics conquering—or they would see it as liberating—Jerusalem. But by 1187 they had lost that sacred city and in 1291 they lost the last bit of the Middle East that they still controlled. Doubt and anxiety reverberated throughout Catholic Europe. If these were holy wars and they were fighting for God against infidels, how could they possibly lose? And since they *did* lose, what did their defeat mean? Surely God must still love them best, they thought, since their religion was the true one. But since God didn't show that love through their victory in these self-proclaimed holy wars, they had to find it elsewhere.

They found it in an imagined white identity.

As Madeline Caviness illustrates, starting in the thirteenth century, western European Catholics replaced pinkish brown hues with whiteness in their artistic self-representations, striving to make their skin more closely resemble the radiant light and purity associated with holiness and divinity as they wrestled with their defeats at darker Muslim hands, building upon centuries of

[7] Lavezzo, Angels on the Edge of the World.

colorism in Christianity that associated darkness with sin, death, and evil.[8] The late thirteenth- or early fourteenth-century Middle English poem *King of Tars* makes the dynamics explicit: to establish peace between their nations, the Catholic princess of Tars, "As white as fether of swan," weds the bloodthirsty sultan of Damascus, a Muslim, although the author portrays him more like a pagan who worships Roman deities. He forces her to renounce Christianity, yet she remains devout in her heart. They eventually have a child, lifeless and monstrous at birth, a gray lump of flesh that lacks limb, blood, and bone, with neither nose nor eye. They pray to the Sultan's Muslim powers to no avail, so he agrees to let his wife try Christianity. And behold! Baptism transforms their lifeless lump into the fairest child ever born, causing the sultan to recognize Christianity as the one true faith and receive baptism himself, resulting in a stunning transformation: "His hide that blac and lothely was, Al white bicom thurth Godes gras" [His skin that was black and hateful, Became all white through God's grace].[9]

Religion here blends into the biology that later became so central to European racism toward other peoples. In the seventeenth and subsequent centuries, Europeans and European Americans advanced the theory of polygenesis, which claimed that each race, classified largely by skin color, descended from separate ancestors and was incapable of creating fertile offspring with other races, despite ample evidence to the contrary, not least the children resulting from the rape of Africans by their European enslavers.[10] As this so-called race science filtered biology through bigotry, so too could medieval religious belonging hinge on the prejudices of the powerful rather than reality. This was also shown the century *before* Europeans proclaimed themselves white to distinguish themselves from darker-skinned Muslims who had beaten them in holy war, when the Irish were rendered no longer Christian so their land could be colonized by the Norman English. The Irish became Christian in the fifth century and had helped spread Christianity throughout Britain and the Continent since the sixth, yet, when England's Norman nobility set imperialist eyes upon Ireland in the twelfth century, the papacy pronounced the Irish fallen from the faith, otherizing them to justify their invasion.

A similar if less explicit dynamic occurred the previous century, when those Normans' great-grandfathers invaded England itself under William, Duke of Normandy, in 1066. Decades later, William's chaplain, William of Poitiers, presented it as a kind of proto-crusade, alleging that the pope had given Duke William his banner and endorsed the conquest in advance, despite the English being Christian since the seventh century and the Normans relatively recent converts. Well into the tenth century, the Normans had been pagan "Vikings" who had massacred, raped, and enslaved Christians, including monks and nuns, throughout Britain, Ireland, and the Continent since the late eighth century. They converted to Christianity as part of the terms for their settlement in northern France, which became known as Normandy, and integrated so thoroughly into Christian culture that, the century after their conversion, they were proclaimed the true Christians while the Christians they had targeted for centuries were deemed deviants, or so William of Poitiers maintained and later Norman English historians would echo.

Shortly after Ireland's invasion began, England's king, Henry II, admitted responsibility for the late December 1170 murder of Thomas Becket, the archbishop of Canterbury, further reducing

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[8] Madeline Caviness, "From the Self-Invention of the Whiteman in the Thirteenth Century to The Good, The Bad, and The Ugly," Different Visions: A Journal of New Perspectives on Medieval Art 1 (2008): 1–33.

[9] The King of Tars, ed. and trans. John Chandler (Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 2016).

[10] Robert Wald Sussman, The Myth of Race: The Troubling Persistence of an Unscientific Idea (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2014).

the credibility of claims that he or his subjects came to Ireland as Christian saviors. Astoundingly, even though Pope Alexander III initially was so outraged that he banned Henry from so much as setting foot inside a church, he eventually proclaimed Henry's colonization of Ireland part of his penance. In 1172, in a letter to his own papal legate in Ireland and its four archbishops, all Irishmen and all representatives of the Catholic hierarchy, Alexander rejoiced that "so devout a son of the Church" as Henry, William of Normandy's great-grandson, had been led by "divine inspiration" to "subject to his dominion that people [i.e., the Irish], a barbarous one uncivilized and ignorant of Divine law." Alexander's concurrent letter to Henry intensified his condemnation of the Irish, whom he claimed had "renounced all reverence for the Christian faith and virtue." He offered virtually unconditional approval of Henry's planned conquest of Ireland, declaring, "We understand that you, collecting your splendid naval and land forces, have set your mind upon subjugating that people to your lordship and, by the Divine grace, extirpating the filthiness of such abomination[.] We hold your purpose good and acceptable in all ways," and urged him to continue it:

we exhort and beseech your majesty and enjoin upon you for the remission of your sins that in this work which you have so laudably begun you will even more intently and strenuously continue, so that, even as you have to the remission of your sins undertaken so great a task as regards that people, so also for the benefit to their souls you shall be worthy of an eternal crown.[11]

Thus the pope presented Ireland's conquest not only as penance for Henry's many sins, which again included responsibility for the murder of England's chief ecclesiastic, but also as spiritually benefitting the Irish.

Alexander's allegation of Irish apostasy, or renunciation of their Christian faith, was political propaganda to provide cover for English imperialist aggression. The only religious failings his letters attribute to the Irish— occasionally eating meat in Lent and not paying tithes nor sufficiently respecting the religious — are minor transgressions that depend upon the supposed offender's Christian identity and obviously pale beside assassinating an archbishop or any of the countless crimes colonists committed. Alexander was exploiting a *fait accompli*, since at least some of the Irish had already accepted Henry in terms analogous to the Irish *ard rí*, or High King, who had limited power over his sub-kings and whose responsibilities included maintaining the balance of power between them.[12] He saw greater profit in an alliance with Henry, despite his responsibility for Becket's martyrdom (Becket was formally canonized in 1173) and previous repeated refusals to honor his crusade vows, than with the decentralized Irish on Europe's outer perimeter, which, alone of Europe west of the Rhine, had never been part of the Roman Empire. Moreover, Henry had already agreed to significant concessions to the church as compensation for Becket's murder, including wealth, property, and once again vowing to go on crusade, a cause that was then going so badly that the Catholics lost Jerusalem permanently 15 years later. Alexander also needed Henry's help against the anti-pope Calixtus III, who was supported by the Holy Roman Emperor, Frederic Barbarossa. His letters reveal less about his attitudes toward, let alone the actual moral condition of, the Irish than they do about his larger strategies involving Henry, who would fail to fulfill virtually all of his promised terms. They also reveal a great deal about the ways in which belonging gets extended and/or

[11] Irish Historical Documents, 1172–1922, ed. Edmund Curtis and R. B. McDowell (London: Methuen, 1968; originally published 1943).

[12] F. J. Byrne, Irish Kings and High-Kings (London: Batsford Press, 1973).

revoked by the dominant, with Christian community here hinging not on actual belief or behavior, but on other people's power and perspective, much like whiteness can function today.

Alexander's *carte blanche* for Henry's invasion of Ireland and his rhetorical dechristianizing of the Irish to provide cover for that invasion did not suffice for the invasion's primary propagandist, Gerald de Barri of Wales, kin to the first wave of colonizers. His *Expugnatio Hibernica*, a "prophetic history" of Ireland's invasion and subsequent colonization, proved so popular that it has to a large extent become the accepted version of history, even though, as F.X. Martin has noted, every one of the eight documents that Gerald claims to reproduce in it is at least to some extent fraudulent.[13] His most influential forgery echoes Alexander's sentiments in his 1172 letters, but projects them back into the past, alleging they came from Alexander's predecessor, Adrian IV, in a letter called *Laudabiliter*, dating to shortly after Henry became king and Adrian pope in 1154. Adrian invariably gets described as "the only English pope," particularly in connection with *Laudabiliter* (Latin for "laudably," the forgery's first word). Gerald himself emphasizes Adrian's Englishness, including when he confuses chronology and identifies the pope at the time of Ireland's invasion as Adrian, "originally from England" (*Adriano papa de Anglia oriundo tunc presidente*), from whom, Gerald says, Henry received "a privilege empowering him, with the pope's full authority and consent, to rule over the Irish people."[14] Adrian, however, died in 1159, when Alexander succeeded him. *Alexander* was the one who consented to Henry's rule over the Irish after he had already partially achieved it through military means, commending him for having "so laudably begun" Ireland's conquest. Moreover, Adrian was English in an Anglo-Saxon sense and cannot be assumed to have felt an ethnic affiliation with Henry II, whose Norman great-grandfather had conquered England and deprived Adrian's people of their land; furthermore, Henry controlled about as much land in France as he did in England and spent more time in France than in England. And, as Adrian himself left England during his adolescence, who knows how "English" he saw *himself*, let alone Henry.

Gerald explicitly referenced Adrian's ethnicity in part to bolster *Laudabiliter*'s authenticity, as indeed it has throughout the centuries, especially since no other Englishman became pope after him. Were it not for Adrian's Englishness, few would fall for the forgery, no matter how convenient the cover story. But Adrian's Englishness has been taken out of context and a later nationalism projected onto him, in part by Gerald himself. Intriguingly, Gerald didn't mention Alexander's actual letters, which conveyed similar sentiments; significantly, however, they did so several years *after* Gerald's kinsmen, the Geraldines, helped initiate Ireland's invasion. Advance blessing from Adrian, fifteen years before the invasion began, could reduce Geraldine guilt for slaughtering their fellow Christians. Gerald first wrote his *Expugnatio* shortly before the Catholics permanently lost Jerusalem and, in the years that followed, he increasingly blamed Henry for waging war on neighboring Catholics in Ireland rather than joining crusade efforts to reclaim the Holy Land for Christ. Ever one to point the finger rather than look in the mirror, Gerald shirked similar accountability for himself or his colonizing kinsmen.

Laudabiliter provided a pretense for the entire invasion upon which Gerald's family's fortunes depended, particularly if it could succeed in convincing Henry's sons and successors to pay Peter's Pence, a donation to the papacy based on the number of households in England dating to Saxon times, for every household in Ireland as well, as *Laudabiliter* alleged Henry had agreed

[13] Giraldus Cambrensis, Expugnatio Hibernica, ed. A. B. Scott and F. X. Martin (Dublin: Royal Irish Academy, 1978).

[14] Cambrensis, Expugnatio Hibernica.

to do. Not only was no such payment ever made for Ireland, however, no pope ever requested it. The first pope to mention *Laudabiliter*, John XXII, did so only after the Irish had sent him a copy in 1317, as part of a petition that the papacy no longer recognize England's kings as Ireland's overlords, since Henry and his descendants had failed to fulfill its terms. John forwarded the petition to Edward II without endorsing *Laudabiliter*'s legitimacy, noting only that Adrian IV "is said" (*dicitur*) to have written it, indicating that he could find no record of it in the papal archives.[15] Moreover, as Barbara Crawford notes, John "did all he could to increase papal revenues and to ensure that all the amounts of papal taxes that were collected were actually received"[16] and also made a full inquiry into Peter's Pence and repeatedly wrote to Edward and the prelates of England and even Scotland about its payment, yet he never pursued the possibility that the papacy was owed Peter's Pence for Ireland, as *Laudabiliter* claimed.[17]

Abundant additional evidence further attests that *Laudabiliter* was a forgery, but it has remained a surprisingly stubborn fiction, in part because of the ways in which Gerald's ethnic slander of the Irish justified their ongoing colonization and dehumanization by the English, providing a potent precursor for similar treatment of indigenous people around the world. Gerald proclaimed the Irish bestial, alleging that they literally reproduced with animals, even including illustrations as "proof." Their skin color was indistinguishable from their colonizers' but, as a hated "Other" to the English since the twelfth century, they eventually came to resemble other groups whom the English later tyrannized and oppressed, including Black Africans. In his 1885 *Races of Britain*, English pseudo-anthropologist John Beddoe maintained that the "real" Irish lived in the regions farthest from England, especially the mountains of Connacht, where he said he saw "the swarthiest people I have ever seen," conforming to "an Irish type […] derive[d] from the race of Cro-Magnon," which he "provisionally" called "Africanoid."[18] Yet they were also recognized as white, including by Beddoe, causing anxiety among English white supremacists, as seen in the words of Charles Kingsley, an Anglican priest, during a visit to Ireland in the years following the mid-nineteenth-century potato Famine.

The Famine, which killed about a million people and forced about two million more to emigrate, resulted primarily from English policies and politics, not an actual food shortage; as Christine Kinealy notes, "In 1847 alone, the worst year of the Famine, almost 4,000 vessels carried food from Ireland to the major ports of Britain, that is Bristol, Glasgow, Liverpool and London."[19] Religious bigotry intensified the divide; England became Protestant amid the Protestant Reformation, while the Irish overwhelmingly remained Catholic. Writing to his wife back in England, Kingsley remarked:

I am daunted by the human chimpanzees I saw along that hundred miles of horrible country. I don't believe they are our fault. I believe that there are not only many more of them than of old, but that they are happier, better and more comfortably fed and lodged under our rule than they

[15] Augustinus Theiner, Vetera Monumenta Hibernorum et Scotorum (Rome, 1864).

[16] Barbara Crawford, "Peter's Pence in Scotland," in The Scottish Tradition: Essays in Honour of Ronald Gordon Cant, ed. G. W. S. Barrow (Edinburgh: Scottish Academic Press, 1974), 14–22.

[17] Calendar of Papal Registers Relating to Great Britain and Ireland: Volume 2, 1305–1342 (Her Majesty's Stationery Office, 1895).

[18] Bruce Nelson, Irish Nationalists and the Making of the Irish Race (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2012).

[19] Christine Kinealy, "Food Exports from Ireland, 1846–47," History Ireland 5, no. 1 (1997): 32–36.

ever were. But to see white chimpanzees is dreadful: if they were black, one would not feel it so much, but their skins, except where tanned by exposure, are as white as ours.[20]

Kingsley's refusal to accept any responsibility for the staggering suffering caused by English exploitation of Ireland, which even Prime Minister Tony Blair—or at least his aides—acknowledged as the Famine's cause in a 1997 apology,[21] and his insistence that the Irish fared better "under our rule" (he offers no point of comparison, and by this point English lordship over at least some of Ireland was nearly 700 years old) echoes efforts to justify slavery as benefitting the enslaved, as American enslavers also alleged about their own "peculiar institution."[22]

Part of the justification for both arose from the victims' dehumanization, including by likening them to apes and chimpanzees, as Kingsley does here. The supposedly white skin of the Irish made him recognize a degree of shared humanity that he "would not feel so much" if they were black, but their Catholic identity increased Protestant antipathy, with some even insisting that starving Irish Catholics could receive food only if they converted to Protestantism and with many blaming the Irish for their own suffering. In Perry Curtis's words,

Because Irish Celts seemed increasingly unwilling or unable to conform to Anglo-Saxon standards of self-control and civility, they began to look ever more similar to those who resented the Irish for being Irish. Anglo-Saxons, after all, could never be accused of having the same physiognomies as Irish Celts. Was it not Pope Gregory I who had observed when passing by a group of fair-haired British [*sic*] youths on sale in the Roman slave market: "Non Angli, sed Angeli?"[23]

Curtis's "British" slip obscures the fact that this was an explicitly English legend and the English were the Britons' oppressors — to such an extent that they eventually became known primarily as Welsh, deriving from a Germanic word meaning "stranger" or even "slave," while their earlier ethnonym became applied to inhabitants of Britain more broadly and especially to the English. Bede characterized the Britons' fate as an extermination of the race,or, in modern terms, genocide; they live on to the present day, but as "strangers" in their own land.[24] Similarly, Irish people along with Britain's other ethnicities often get lumped under the term "Anglo," partly because English is now the dominant language on both islands, bolstered by government policies that have only recently been redressed. For example, the Identity and Language Act of Northern Ireland officially recognized the Irish language only in 2022, analogous to official recognition of Welsh in Wales in 1993 and Gaelic in Scotland in 2005. The Famine had a particularly devastating impact on the Irish language, which today remains extremely endangered, despite ongoing sustainability efforts in the Irish Republic. Similarly,

[20] Charles Kingsley: His Letters and Memories of His Life, ed. Frances E. Kingsley (London: Macmillan and Co., 1894).

[21] Ryan Hooper, "Tony Blair's Apology for Irish Famine Written by Aides, Papers Reveal," The Standard, July 20, 2021, https://www.standard.co.uk/news/uk/tony-blair-apology-irish-famine-written-aides-b946647.html.

[22] Kenneth M. Stampp, The Peculiar Institution: Slavery in the Ante-Bellum South (New York: Vintage Books, 1956).

[23] L. Perry Curtis, Apes and Angels: The Irishman in Victorian Caricature, 2nd ed. (Washington, DC: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1997).

[24] Bede, Ecclesiastical History

approximately 300 native languages existed in what later became the United States in the sixteenth century, but, as of 2022, only 175 remain.[25]

Those Irish who could escape the Famine often fled to the United States, where American white supremacists, eventually called WASPs, meaning White Anglo-Saxon Protestants, caricatured them as a mongrel race, as Africans at their core who had been whitened by their time in Europe—ignorant of the fact that that applies essentially to all Europeans, who ultimately descend from Africans, as does humanity generally, with lighter skin a response to northern climates' less intense sunlight. Some echoed Beddoe in their insistence that the Irish were physically black, further illustrating the illusion of both whiteness and blackness. Human skin rarely reflects either actual hue but instead varying shades of brown, yellow, and red; nevertheless, Americans continue to cling to this color scheme's distortions. By the early twentieth century, in what Nell Irvin Painter calls "the second great enlargement of American whiteness" the Irish integrated into a kind of second-class white identity, a fragile sense of belonging too often shored up by bigotry directed at others even farther from a fantasy WASP center.[26] Many fell for something akin to what Valarie Kaur calls "the great bribe of white supremacy: the promise of acceptance for people of color who put down other people of color," a promise that is ultimately deception, like whiteness itself.[27] This divide and conquer strategy primarily served the interests of the privileged, as reflected in English politician Edward Freeman's 1883 remark that during his recent visit to the U.S., "Very many approved when I suggested the best remedy for whatever was amiss would be if every Irishman should kill a negro and be hanged for it." Those who dissented did so primarily because without either ethnicity they would have no servants.[28]

As Frederick Douglass, who spent over a year in Ireland as he eluded enslavers in 1845-46, remarked, the Irish still in Ireland proved less susceptible to bigotry's bargain:

The Irish, who, at home, readily sympathize with the oppressed everywhere, are instantly taught when they step upon our [American] soil to hate and despise the Negro. They are taught to believe that he eats the bread that belongs to them. The cruel lie is told to them, that we deprive them of labor and receive the money which would otherwise make its way into their pockets. Sir, the Irish-American will one day find out his mistake.[29]

Partly this was because evidence of ongoing English oppression surrounded the Irish throughout Ireland, at least prior to the independence of 26 of its 32 counties in the twentieth century. The English began their plantation system, which later inflicted such horrors on and became synonymous with the American South, in Ireland, specifically Laois and Offaly, in 1556, as a buffer to protect the area to which the English colony in Ireland had been effectively reduced by the fifteenth century. Called the Pale, it stretched around Dublin from Dundalk to Dalkey and gave rise to the expression "beyond the Pale," as the English regarded everything outside of it as uncivilized, since it was dominated by the native Irish and English colonists who had assimilated so thoroughly into Irish culture as to seem indistinguishable, with land seized

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[25] Climate in Arts and History, "Effects of Colonization and Climate Change on Indigenous Languages," n.d., https://www.science.smith.edu/climatelit/effects-of-colonization-and-climate-change-on-indigenous-languages/.

[26] Nell Irvin Painter, The History of White People (New York: W. W. Norton & Co., 2010).

[27] Valarie Kaur, See No Stranger: A Memoir and Manifesto of Revolutionary Love (New York: One World, 2020).

[28] Edward A. Freeman, Some Impressions of the United States (New York: Henry Holt & Co., 1883).

[29] Frederick Douglass, The Life and Times of Frederick Douglass (Mineola, NY: Dover Publications Inc., 2003; originally published 1892).

from both groups to create these English plantations in Ireland. This system soon overlapped with the one in the American colonies and at times involved the same people, as with Lord Delaware, about whom a 1610 letter noted, "It is hoped the plantation of Ireland may be shortly settled. The Lord Delaware is preparing to depart for the plantation of Virginia."[30]

English colonists saw multiple commonalities between the Irish and indigenous Americans, including their clothes and homes, their agricultural practices, their sexual and marital mores, and of course their supposed blood-thirsty savagery when protecting themselves from invasion, colonization, and genocide. Howard Mumford Jones notes that portraits

of Ireland and the Irish preceded or accompanied the voyage literature having to do with the New World, that English experience with one wild race conditioned their expectation of experience with another […] Doubtless the Spaniards, the Portuguese, and the French were equally brutal in a cruel and brutal age, but the doctrine that the only good Indian is a dead Indian first took shape, it would appear, in the doctrine that the only good wild Irishman is a dead wild Irishman. […] Used to savagery in the one place, they looked for it, they provoked it, in the other.[31]

One could add "they perpetrated it," but they deemed their own actions not savage but necessary. Like the Israelites with the Canaanites, it's not genocide when the killers tell the tale; rather, it's God's will and human progress. As Captain John Underhill wrote in his journal, "Newes from America," defending his 1637 massacre of a Pequot village near Mystic, Connecticut, to critics who asked, "Should not Christians have more mercy and compassion?," he responded, "Sometimes the Scripture declareth women and children must perish […] We had sufficient light from the word of God for our proceedings."[32]

Similar sentiments also surface in Bede's *Ecclesiastical History*, but directed against Christian victims of pagan violence. His construction of whiteness parallels his concurrent imperialist construction of Christian identity defined by the whims of power, not actual belief or behavior, as happened again against the Irish in the twelfth century. In that case, however, both invaders and indigenous were Catholic Christians. Bede's eighth-century account of his sixth-century Germanic pagan ancestors' invasion of Britain proclaims *them* God's true elect, as opposed to the Christian Britons they slaughtered. He celebrates Æthelfrith of Northumbria's massacre of 1200 monks from Bangor, whom he declares false Christians who deserved death while they prayed, even as he acknowledges that they were defenseless before "barbarians' swords." He insists this fulfills God's plans of making the Germanic English God's new chosen people, a supersessionist replacement of not just Jews but also Israel, with England itself the new Promised Land. Bede implicitly transforms the Britons into the Philistines or Canaanites and explicitly twists Christian prayers into "persecution" of their pagan executioners. As Alexander Murray notes, Bede needed these "bad Britons to offset against the good English."[33] Since good meant Christian and bad British, he bestowed pagans butchering monks armed only with their prayers with honorary Christian status and denied their victims their actual Christian identity, demonstrating that the ultimate determinant isn't religious affiliation but the power to define

[30] David B. Quinn, The Elizabethans and the Irish (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1966).

[31] Howard Mumford Jones, O Strange New World: American Culture, The Formative Years (New York: Viking Press, 1964).

[32] John Mason, A Brief History of the Pequot War (Bedford, MA: Applewood Books, 2009; originally published 1736).

[33] Alexander Murray, "Bede and the Unchosen Race," in Power and Identity in the Middle Ages: Essays in Memory of Rees Davies, ed. Huw Pryce and John Watts (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 52–67.

some as "us" and others as "them." Power, however, is not a constant; four centuries later, around 1125, the hybrid historian William of Malmesbury, son of an English mother and Norman father, offered his own super-supersessionist revision, with the Normans replacing the English replacing the Israelites as God's chosen, while England remained the new Israel.

About sixty years after William wrote, Gerald penned his *Expugnatio Hibernica*, which he called a "prophetic history," in part because he included supposed prophecies by saints that purportedly pointed to Ireland's colonization by the English, but also because he hoped it would bring about the future he sought, including regarding Peter's Pence. In this Gerald failed, but his writings proved prophetic in other ways, becoming a blueprint not just for anti-Irish ideology in a pro-English world, but for global imperialism when nearly "no more of the world left" remained for Europeans to colonize, as Gerald said about Henry's addition of Ireland to his realm. Tribalistic tendencies are inherent in humanity, but they became a truly global plague through western European global imperialist expansion starting at the end of the Middle Ages, which effectively caused the shift to modernity. Other European powers played significant parts, but the English eventually dominated this global imperialism, and "off-island" English imperialism began with Ireland's invasion in 1169, with Gerald its primary propagandist.

Since the eighth century, the English proclaimed themselves God's chosen people and cited as proof their supposedly white skin. In the thirteenth and subsequent centuries, Europeans adopted this fictive pigmentation more broadly as they struggled to make sense of their ongoing defeats in what they proclaimed holy wars, seeking proof of God's preference for them in their skin when it eluded them militarily. The English sometimes pronounced the Britons/Welsh dark and depraved, as in the tenth-century Exeter Cathedral Manuscript MS 3501, which demonstrates that "color prejudice existed in the Middle Ages, in ways that closely resemble modern racism," as Coral Lumbley observes.[34] Gerald de Barri, a quarter Welsh himself, also called attention to Welsh darkness, but to celebrate their supposed Trojan origins, whereas the Irish he faulted for being hairy, punning on the similar sound of beards (*barbas*) and barbarian (*barbarus*) and intensifying connections with the beasts they supposedly mated with. Ireland's invasion, led by Gerald's kin, predates the Catholics' loss of Jerusalem by less than twenty years. Gerald occasionally likened it to a crusade as justification, as William of Poitiers did with the Norman invasion of England, but in later revisions of his *Expugnatio* he increasingly condemned it as an attack on fellow Christians when they should have been saving the Holy Land from Muslims. In the broader Norman English imagination, the Irish remained both savage strangers on their doorstep who needed to be colonized and controlled and a profoundly Christian people who produced a disproportionate number of saints and inhabited a terrestrial paradise that had been deplorably soaked with their blood. Native Americans, however, had no shroud of Christian kinship to shield them when European powers arrived on their shores and insisted on a divine right to claim their home as Europeans' own.

King of Tars, which explicitly equated Christian with white and non-Christian with black, was written by 1330. The following century European exploration of lands beyond their known world expanded far beyond their imaginations, and concomitantly intensified their rhetoric against Muslims and unspecified "pagans" in the papal letters that laid the groundwork for the doctrine of discovery. This isn't so much an actual doctrine as repeated insistence on European Catholic supremacy in various papal letters during the "Age of Discovery," encouraging secular

[34] Coral Lumbley, "The 'Dark Welsh': Color, Race, and Alterity in the Matter of Medieval Wales," Literature Compass 16 (2019): 1–19.

leaders to conquer foreign lands in Christ's name. In 1452, Pope Nicholas V granted King Alfonso of Portugal the right to subjugate and enslave Muslims, pagans, and other supposed enemies of Christ. Three years later, Nicholas encouraged Henry the Navigator's efforts to find a faster route to India—not for glory and gold but for God, seeking Christians in India who might join with them to defeat Islam once and for all, "and might also be able forthwith to subdue certain gentile or pagan peoples, living between, who are entirely free from infection by the sect of the most impious Mahomet, and to preach and cause to be preached to them the unknown but most sacred name of Christ." From the papal perspective, the Age of Discovery was really a means to finally win the original white Christian "Lost Cause," the crusades. To that end, as God's representative, Nicholas endorsed Henry's efforts to subdue and enslave Muslims, pagans, "and other enemies of Christ wheresoever placed."[35]

Less than 40 years later, Columbus sailed the ocean blue, irrevocably changing the world in the process. But the more things change, the more they stay the same. The papacy's objective continued to be defeating Muslims and finding Christian allies to help do so, as expressed in Alexander VI's *Inter Caetera* in 1493. Written to Ferdinand and Isabella of Spain, it declares,

Among other works well pleasing to the Divine Majesty and cherished of our heart, this assuredly ranks highest, that in our times especially the Catholic faith and the Christian religion be exalted and everywhere increased and spread, that the health of souls be cared for and that barbarous nations be overthrown and brought to the faith itself. [… Since Christopher Columbus has helped you discover previously unknown lands,] we of our own accord, not at your instance nor the request of anyone else in your regard, but of our own sole largess and certain knowledge and out of the fullness of our apostolic power, by the authority of Almighty God conferred upon us in blessed Peter and of the vicarship of Jesus Christ which we hold on earth, do by tenor of these presents give, grant, and assign forever to you and your heirs and successors, kings of Castile and Leon, all and singular the aforesaid countries and islands thus unknown and hitherto discovered by your envoys and to be discovered hereafter, *provided however they at no time have been in the actual temporal possession of any Christian owner*, together with all their dominions, cities, camps, places, and villages, and all rights, jurisdictions, and appurtenances of the same.[36]

About 30 years later the Protestant Reformation ripped western Europe apart and a key objective in western Europeans' so-called "exploration" became defeating Christian opponents no less than Muslims and pagans. Such sentiments can also be seen in twelfth-century papal letters aimed at the Irish—Catholic Christians far longer than their colonizers, whose ancestors they had in fact helped convert, but deemed Christian in name only in an attempt to sanction their land's colonization. Protestants rejected the papacy but echoed its fifteenth-century rhetoric, as in Elizabeth I's 1578 patent to Humphrey Gilbert to explore and colonize "remote, heathen and barbarous lands, countreys and territories not actually possessed of any Christian prince or people" in North America, indicative of the general sense among European authorities that land uninhabited by Christians was *terra nullius*, no one's land, and theirs for the taking.[37]

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[35] European Treaties Bearing on the History of the United States and Its Dependencies to 1648, ed. Frances Gardiner Davenport (Washington, DC: Carnegie Institution of Washington, 1917).

[36] Davenport, European Treaties

[37] The Principal Navigations, Voyages, Traffiques and Discoveries of the English Nation, collected by Richard Hakluyt, ed. Edmund Godsmid (Edinburgh: E. & G. Godsmid, 1889).

Such claims became part of U.S. law in 1823 through the Supreme Court case *Johnson v. M'Intosh*, which, as Lindsay Robertson explains, "announced the so-called discovery doctrine, which provided that, upon discovery of the continent, European sovereigns acquired title to all discovered lands, while indigenous peoples retained only an 'occupancy' right that could be transferred only to the same discovering sovereigns."[38] It has been reinforced as recently as 2005 in the Supreme Court's ruling on *City of Sherill v. Oneida Indian Nation of New York*, which noted that "Under the 'doctrine of discovery ,' […] 'fee title to the lands occupied by Indians when the colonists arrived became vested in the sovereign—first the discovering European nation and later the original States and the United States.'"[39] As Steven Newcomb notes in *Pagans in the Promised Land*, European powers relied on Old Testament ideology in proclaiming themselves the rightful rulers of the non-Christian lands they "discovered," but their dominance really depended upon conquest, which lacks the moral authority of being chosen by God to "save savages." As Newcomb implores his audience,

> it is not merely for the sake of humans that we must shift away from the "subdue" and "dominion" mentality and behaviors traced to the Old Testament and ancient Christendom. We must also do so for the sake of all living things, including Mother Earth and our future generations. As the Original Nations and Peoples of Great Turtle Island, we must invite the world to walk with us on this beautiful path of life in keeping with a central teaching of indigenous law: Respect the Earth as our Mother, and Have a Sacred Regard for All Living Things.[40]

Climate change exponentially intensifies this urgency, which grows more extreme every day. Whiteness, English imperialism, and crusade defeats lie at the root of the European sense of entitlement to and exploitation of the world's resources, fueling this ongoing destruction of our planet and its inhabitants. European colonization began in Europe, inflicted upon neighbors who gradually assimilated into the colonial system at home and then around the world, creating ever-expanding levels of destruction that threaten the entire planet. Fuller understanding of this history can help us address its consequences, at least while we still have a window to defuse what António Guterres, Secretary-General of the United Nations, has called "[t]he climate time-bomb," with humanity "a weapon of mass extinction."[41]

Conclusion

The "not Angles but Angels" legend does not originate with Bede, although his telling became definitive. It also appears in Gregory's earliest biography, which predates Bede by a few decades, and both Bede and this Life attribute it to oral tradition, which Bede realizes has dubious reliability.[42] Thus even the earliest sources recognize whiteness as a myth. Its suspect nature calls to mind Ignatius of Loyola's claim that a good Catholic "ought always to hold that

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[38] Lindsay G. Robertson, Conquest by Law: How the Discovery of America Dispossessed Indigenous Peoples of Their Lands (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005).

[39] City of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation of New York, 544 U.S. 197 (2005), 337 F.3d 139, https://www.law.cornell.edu/supct/html/03-855.ZO.html.

[40] Steven T. Newcomb, Pagans in the Promised Land: Decoding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (Golden, CO: Fulcrum Publishing, 2008).

[41] Laura Paddison, "'The Climate Time-Bomb Is Ticking': The World Is Running Out of Time to Avoid Catastrophe, New UN Report Warns," CNN, March 20, 2023, https://www.cnn.com/2023/03/20/world/ipcc-synthesis-report-climate-intl/index.html.

[42] Bede, Ecclesiastical History.

the white which I see, is black, if the Hierarchical church so decides it."[43] Ignatius advocates such obedience to the church that the faithful substitute its perspective for reality, as the Irish were expected to do when Alexander III proclaimed them no longer Christian so they could be "saved" by a man who incited his own archbishop's assassination; heightening his claims' surreality, he wrote them to the Roman Catholic ecclesiastical hierarchy's chief Irish representatives, one of whose Irish name he Latinized as Catholic (Cadhla Ua Dubthaig, Archbishop of Tuam) and another as Christian (Gilla Críst Ua Connairche, Bishop of Lismore and papal legate).

Ignatius's assertion holds particular relevance for race, not least as human skin tones rarely include actual "white" or "black." European whiteness was an invention, emerging first among the English to emphasize their own allegedly angelic appearance before being adopted by western Europeans more broadly in the thirteenth century, as they struggled to make sense of their defeats to darker-skinned Muslims in their self-proclaimed holy wars. The century before western Europeans wrapped themselves in whiteness to perpetuate a pretense of divine preference, the Irish became no longer Christian, at least to the extent it condoned their colonization, and later also had their "whiteness" denied by bigots in Britain and their fellow travelers in the United States. Identification with whiteness intensified as Europeans encountered and exploited more and more people with skin darker than theirs amid the so-called Age of Discovery, but whiteness has served as a foundation for European identity since at least the eighth century.

Origin myths help us understand ourselves and the world around us, intertwining invented "truths" with alleged ancestral memories. The more we have been socialized to accept them as authentic, the less we recognize their falsehoods. For example, my "white" students often have never consciously recognized that their skin isn't actually white, a reality that ought to stare them in the face, and almost none have previously learned how "white" people became "Caucasians," a mostly meaningless label when applied to anyone except those from the Caucasus region, where Eastern Europe meets Asia. It became the term for certain western Europeans during eighteenth- and nineteenth-century racist attempts at anthropology. Up until relatively recently, some western Europeans were deliberately excluded from this "race," especially the Irish and Highland Scots, along with southern Europeans like Greeks and Italians, eastern Europeans of any kind, including those with the most claim to "Caucasian," and of course the perennial European "Other," the Jews. These labels, "white" and "Caucasian," get used in government documents along with countless other official records, yet both are fabrications, used to bolster bigger lies about the innate superiority of those to whom they get applied.

The more power a people has, the more they define reality—such as portraying the Irish as sacrilegious sex-crazed savages, allegations also recycled against indigenous Americans —and the more potential they have for abuse, such as colonizing, killing, and enslaving indigenous people with impunity and proclaiming it God's will. Whiteness symbolizes power and authority and, like Christian identity, could be revoked according to the whims of the dominant, as occurred repeatedly when Christians were denied their faith identity when those who coveted their lands told the tale—be it Bede about the Britons or Gerald de Barri about the Irish. In ways Christianity begins with appropriation, claiming the Hebrew Bible as their Old Testament, superseded by the New Testament, with Christians casting themselves as God's new

[43] Ignatius of Loyola, Spiritual Exercises, ed. and trans. Elder Mullan, S.J. (New York: P. J. Kennedy and Sons, 1914).

Elect and the lands they occupy—whether it's Britain or what becomes the United States—as the new Israel. As exploitative as this rhetoric is towards people, it is exponentially more so towards the land and what Pottawatomi poet-scientist Robin Wall Kimmerer calls its "more-than-human" inhabitants, plants and animals.[44] We are not doomed to repeat this same old script, however. As Walter Lippmann, the journalist who coined the term stereotypes, recognized, history is the "antiseptic" that helps clear our prejudices so we can "realize more and more clearly when our ideas started, where they started, how they came to us, why we accepted them."[45] Understanding the origins of white supremacy and its fellow traveler, Christian supremacy, along with their false foundations and their history of dehumanizing an ever-rotating cast of targets to justify colonization, oppression, and enslavement, can better equip us to more effectively combat their contemporary manifestations and avoid their perpetuation. The future of the planet just might depend upon it.

[44] Robin Wall Kimmerer, Braiding Sweetgrass: Indigenous Wisdom, Scientific Knowledge, and the Teachings of Plants (Minneapolis: Milkweed Editions, 2013).

[45] Walter Lippmann, Public Opinion (London: George Allen & Unwin, Ltd., 1922).